

Green vs. growth in ETS showdown

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What's driving the day in Brussels. By GERARDO FORTUNA CIAO THERE. Gerardo Fortuna back with you this Friday, but mentally already at Sunday's World C

What's driving the day in Brussels.

By GERARDO FORTUNA

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CIAO THERE. Gerardo Fortuna back with you this Friday, but mentally already at Sunday's World Cup final. My money's on Argentina — see whether Brussels' top dogs agree below (spoiler alert: they don't).

In today's Playbook:

- Stressed to the max: Burnout is the top reason EU diplomats call in sick.
- The European Parliament has been missing one lawmaker. That could change.
- Faces in the crowd: Thierry Breton, Jessica Rosencrantz, Mykhailo Fedorov, Wopke Hoekstra, Antoni Comín i Oliveres, Stéphane Séjourné, Bert Schreurs, Ursula von der Leyen, Yevhenii Khmara, Teresa Ribera, Krzysztof Bolesła, Michael McGrath, Raffaele Fitto, Cristiano Sebastiani, Apostolos Tzitzikostas and many more...

On today's Brussels Playbook Week Ender podcast: Sarah talks summer travel — passenger rights, border check headaches and the jet fuel crisis that wasn't — with Jordyn Dahl, Tommaso Lecca and Ben Munster.

DRIVING THE DAY

SEEING RED OVER GREEN RULES: The European Commission is set to announce two flagship proposals today: a move to water down the EU's flagship anti-climate change policy ; and a plan to boost the energy transition. The first of the two — the long-awaited review of the Emissions Trading System (ETS) — spells trouble.

Deep divisions: The revamp is already pitting EU members against one another and splitting Commission President Ursula von der Leyen's top team.

Up in smoke: The Commission's ETS overhaul is in response to rising energy prices and fears from Europe's industrial base — along with pressure from national governments. The rules, which impose costs on polluters, are expected to be relaxed so heavy industry will be allowed to emit more planet-warming emissions for longer. Under existing regulation, sectors covered by the ETS must reach

zero by 2039, but proposed changes would push out that target.

The thinking: The ETS revamp is designed to assuage private-sector concerns that business can't survive in the bloc under existing settings, according to two EU officials, six diplomats and Commission documents seen by POLITICO.

Unhappy family: Whatever the logic, the move is proving controversial inside the Berlaymont. When officials met earlier this week, at least three cabinets formally tabled objections to the plans, two of those working on the file told Gabriel Gavin and Ben Makuch.

Among the recalcitrant commissioners are industry chief Stéphane Séjourné, transport czar Apostolos Tzitzikostas and Raffaele Fitto, a former minister in the government of ETS-skeptic Italian PM Giorgia Meloni .

Institutional warfare: But even if the Commission comes to an agreement internally, it will be an uphill battle to secure a deal with EU capitals and a bitterly divided European Parliament. The fight will define the rest of the year, if there's any hope of achieving consensus in the first half of 2027.

EPP weighs in: The EU's center-right European People's Party, the largest group in Parliament and the political home of almost half of the Commission, has begun a campaign for an "even more moderate" approach to reducing emissions. The party also used its influence to ensure one of its MEPs, Germany's Peter Liese, would take the lead on the file when it gets to negotiations with lawmakers.

Call to action: "Our European way of life was built on the power of our industries. Today this power is wavering," Polish Secretary of State Krzysztof Bolesław told Playbook. "Many companies see ETS as one of the problems ... We will do whatever we can to deliver a pragmatic revision that ditches dogmatism and gives member states and industries a strong helping hand."

Pushing back: But Sweden's Europe Minister Jessica Rosencrantz told POLITICO that "the ETS works. Europe should build on its success, not retreat from it," and that she would fight to keep the policy as intact as possible. The Spanish government warned that "preserving its ambition" is essential for both the planet and economic competitiveness, in a letter sent to Wopke Hoekstra and Teresa Ribera, two of the EU's most pro-green commissioners, and seen by POLITICO.

Watch this space: The final details, which have been kept so tightly under wraps that even Commissioners have been asked to read the report in a secure room, are expected to move markets ... and will see Brussels forced to decide between two hot priorities: tackling climate change or boosting European industry.

BIG AND BREAKING

EXCLUSIVE — COMMISSION VS. SPAIN AND HUNGARY: Landing at today's College of Commissioners meeting: the executive's annual Rule of Law report. Sebastian Starcevic has the scoop on what Brussels will say about two countries already under the spotlight when it comes to anti-corruption measures: Spain and Hungary.

Four tests: The report will grade EU countries on judicial independence, anti-corruption safeguards, media freedom and institutional checks. "It gives us a clear picture of where we are succeeding and where challenges remain," Justice Commissioner Michael McGrath told Playbook.

SIX DAYS OF STRIKES: U.S. forces hit Iran for a sixth straight day Thursday, further clouding prospects of talks between Washington and Tehran. Overnight, projectiles struck Qeshm Island and near Bandar Abbas, on the Strait of Hormuz, Reuters reports .

ZELENSKY'S DEFENSE SHAKE-UP: Ukraine's security chief Yevhenii Khmara is set to become the country's acting defense minister . But the ousting of 35-year-old reformer Mykhailo Fedorov — popular at home and abroad — has already sparked protests .

COPYING AMERICA: Brussels thinks Europe's banks are losing ground to Wall Street. The Commission will unveil plans today to cut red tape for lenders , taking a page from the U.S. playbook in the name of competitiveness.

EU ENGINE CHECK: Friedrich Merz and Emmanuel Macron launched two days of Franco-German talks with a promise to strengthen Europe's defense, industry and tech — and reassure doubters that the EU's traditional power couple can still deliver.

TURNBERRY CHECK-IN: Nearly a year after von der Leyen and U.S. President Donald Trump sealed their trade truce in Scotland, many of their headline promises — from energy purchases to regulatory cooperation — are looking increasingly difficult to deliver .

TRUMP WARNS OF CHINESE INTERFERENCE: The U.S. president used a speech overnight to announce his administration is declassifying documents that he claims show Chinese interference in U.S. elections. He went on to say the TV networks that didn't feature live coverage of his address should have their broadcast licenses revoked .

EEAS BURNOUT

STRESSED: Burnout was the most common sick-leave diagnosis at the EU's diplomatic service between April 2025 and March 2026, accounting for around 28 percent of cases, according to a document obtained by Zoya Sheftalovich.

The details: The EEAS recorded 1,751 medical certificates between April 2025 and March 2026, according to information released through an access-to-documents request. Of those, 263 were examined by the Commission's Medical Control Unit, which checks whether an employee's sick leave is medically justified. The cases are selected either randomly or at the administration's request, meaning the data covers only a sample of all medical certificates. Burnout accounted for just under 28 percent of the controlled cases.

Reminder: Around 8 percent of staff at the EEAS took stress- or burnout-related leave in 2025, a senior EEAS official recently told POLITICO . The Commission at the time said that figure was "completely unfounded," adding that "no such statistic exists, neither for EEAS nor European Commission, as absences for medical reasons are protected by medical confidentiality."

More precisely: Presented with the data POLITICO obtained, the Commission maintained its original answer was "factually accurate" as a "direct, narrow response" to the claim that 8 percent of staff were on burnout-related leave — while acknowledging some figures do exist. "Please allow us to be more precise," the EU executive said. "What the Commission does have is statistical estimates for the proportion of medical referrals related to burnout."

In other words: While it may not have had figures for the share of all EEAS staff on burnout leave, its categorical claim that “no such statistic exists” omitted relevant data it did hold.

Expert view: Bert Schreurs, a VUB professor of human resources management, told Sebastian: “I don’t think this is very high, to be honest … Relative to what we see in Belgium, it’s lower.” But Cristiano Sebastiani, president of EU staff union Renouveau & Démocratie, said the figures may actually understate the problem because employees are often reluctant to attribute their symptoms to burnout.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

The EU General Court last week dismissed Apple’s challenge against how it was designated under the bloc’s Big Tech rules. But what is the General Court? It’s the lower of the two courts that make up the Court of Justice of the European Union, which is based in Luxembourg (the superior court is the Court of Justice). The General Court has 54 judges, two from each member country, and deals primarily with cases brought by individuals, companies and organizations challenging decisions made by the EU’s institutions and its other bodies.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

CATALAN PARLIAMENT-BOUND

MISSING PIECE OF THE PUZZLE: The European Parliament has 720 seats. But since the June 2024 election, only 719 of them have been occupied. The missing MEP is Antoni Comín i Oliveres, of Catalonia’s pro-independence Together for Catalonia (Junts) party. He has been unable to take up his seat because returning to Spain (required to kick-start his mandate) could lead to his arrest.

That was then: Yesterday’s ruling by the EU’s top court found that an amnesty offered to Comín and former Catalan President Carles Puigdemont, after their prosecution over the region’s illegal 2017 independence referendum, doesn’t breach EU law. This clears the way for Comín to take up his seat — although Spain’s highest courts could still delay the amnesty’s implementation.

Reminder: After the referendum, Puigdemont and Comín faced charges and fled to Brussels. To secure the backing of pro-independence parties, Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez later introduced an amnesty for those involved. Spanish courts delayed its implementation by referring questions to the Court of Justice of the EU in Luxembourg.

Renew could grow: Comín’s Together for Catalonia is now in talks to join the centrist European Democratic Party, according to two people familiar with the discussions. This would see the party sit within the liberal Renew Europe group. Together for Catalonia declined to comment.

8 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

RUSSIA’S HAND? Polish prosecutors have indicted an 18-year-old Ukrainian accused of carrying out Russian-directed sabotage aimed at inflaming an already sensitive dispute about World War II between Warsaw and Kyiv.

MELONI GETS HER WAY: Italy's lower house approved Giorgia Meloni's contentious electoral reform , despite signs of cracks in her coalition after the government lost a key vote earlier this week.

NO THANKS, ELON: Why France's National Rally could do without an endorsement from the world's first trillionaire.

FARMING FUND SCANDAL IN GREECE: The European Public Prosecutor's Office has brought its first criminal case against Greek lawmakers over the country's widening EU farm funds scandal.

BRETON GETS A REPRIEVE: A U.S. judge has paused the Trump administration's visa restrictions targeting disinformation researchers and digital regulators, including former European Commissioner Thierry Breton.

BORDER, FINALLY: Nearly 400 years after France and the Netherlands agreed to split Saint Martin , France's parliament has finally put the Caribbean island's border into law.

WORLD CUP BANNER ROW: A senior U.K. minister wants FIFA to investigate the "entirely inappropriate" banner displayed by some Argentina players after beating England to reach the World Cup final.

FINAL WHISTLE? NOT YET: The EU's top court backed FIFA on its football agent rules — but Germany's judges still have the last word. More in Morning Fair Play (for Pro subscribers).

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Mainly sunny, top of 26C.

T-2 TO THE FINAL: POLITICO polled the great and the good of the Brussels bubble to hear which team they think will win the World Cup final on Sunday night. And there's not much love for Argentina ...

Glenn Micallef, European commissioner for sport: 2-0 Spain.

Magnus Brunner, European commissioner for internal affairs and migration: "Both [teams] almost lost to Austria (just kidding), but the strong historical Austria-Spain connection compels me to say 2-1 for Spain. And because I hope an EU country wins!"

Paula Pinho, European Commission chief spokesperson: 1-1 in regulation time, and Spain wins on penalties.

Jüri Laas, spokesperson for European Parliament President Roberta Metsola: "Hoping for positive and entertaining football. Probably a close game. Europe wins. Spain 2, Argentina 1."

Marcos Alonso Alonso, Spanish ambassador to the EU: "We're sure that La Roja will bring joy to Europe."

Fernando Iglesias, Argentina's ambassador to the EU: "May the final be the best, and may the best win the final (I mean: Messi)."

Thomas Regnier, European Commission spokesperson and former professional footballer: "Spain wins 2-1. Messi scores his last World Cup goal from the spot."

Pieter Jan Kleiweg de Zwaan, Dutch ambassador to the EU: "It has to be Spain. 2-0. Argentina has been so lucky and it has to be a European country."

Roxana Mînzatu, executive vice president of the European Commission: "Looking forward to the Messi-Yamal duel and expecting an exciting match. Too close to call."

Christophe Hansen, European commissioner for agriculture: "Spain will be the first country in history to win the World Cup only conceding a single goal on the way. 2-0."

Ignazio Cocchiere, European Commission official and former professional footballer: "I say 2-1 Spain. The UEFA European champions against the Copa America and World Cup holders, you can't ask for a better final. Spanish captain Rodri to be player of the match."

Edouard Philippe, former French PM, mayor of Le Havre and presidential candidate : "3-1 pour l'Espagne."

Petros Fassoulas, secretary general of the European Movement: "I've always supported Spain in the absence of Greece in the competition, even though I'm a big fan of Messi. I think it will be a 2-1 win for Spain."

Carrie Budoff Brown, POLITICO Europe's executive editor: "3-2 to Argentina. Messi pulls it out."

SPOTTED... at the Dutch Permanent Representation's summer party, saying farewell to spokesperson Melle van Dijk: Dutch Ambassador to the EU Pieter Jan Kleiweg de Zwaan; the Dutch Perm Rep's Anne-Sophie van Vegchel and Demy van 't Wout; Danish Perm Rep's Fabrice Jacobsen; German Perm Rep's Julian Fricke; Belgian Perm Rep's Sofia Smorscek; De Telegraaf's Alexander Bakker; Trouw's Romana Abels; NOS's Ardy Stemerding and Roemer Ockhuijsen; NRC's Rik Rutten and Michel Kerres; de Volkskrant's Marc Peepkorn; Algemeen Dagblad's Sander van Mersbergen; ANP's Yolanda de Koster and Lauren Heeremans; Reuters' Andrew Gray; Le Monde's Philippe Jacqu ; Contexte's Anca Gurzu, Clothilde Goujard and Sean Carroll; FT's Henry Foy and Laura Dubois; Euronews' Peggy Corlin and Jorge Liboreiro; Euractiv's Nicoletta Ionta and Thomas Moller-Nielsen; Bloomberg's Suzanne Lynch and Jorge Valero; POLITICO's Koen Verhelst, Nicholas Vinocur, Gerardo Fortuna, Zia Weise, Gabriel Gavin and Camille Gijss.

All the best: Van Dijk will take up an assignment in the Dutch prime minister's office working on economic security and will be succeeded by Rutger Fransen, arriving from the foreign ministry in The Hague. Some staff serenaded van Dijk in Dutch. I was only able to catch one pun: Melle rhyming with bellen ("to call") — with a little help from my Dutch-speaking colleagues.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: AI and microelectronics, along with the expansion of the hydrogen corridor, will be the focus of today's Franco-German Council of Ministers.

London: Andy Burnham will use a victory speech today to add some brushstrokes to his plans for when he becomes prime minister on Monday.

Paris: Marine Le Pen's team has been brainstorming ideas for the presidential candidate's political platform. But advisers have been told not to breathe a word .

Washington PM: Speaker Mike Johnson continues his struggle to control the House floor , with Republicans yanking a veterans' bill after straining to muster support.

AGENDA

- European Commission Executive Vice President Teresa Ribera hosts a press conference with Climate Commissioner Wopke Hoekstra and Energy Commissioner Dan Jørgensen on the Energy Package and the review of the EU Emissions Trading System.
- Meeting of the College of Commissioners.
- Executive Vice-President Roxana Mînzatu meets representatives of the European Trade Union Committee for Education (ETUCE)
- Executive Vice President Raffaele Fitto participates remotely in the conference “A Safer Mediterranean for a Stronger Europe.”
- Information meeting of justice and home affairs ministers. Details [here](#).
- 26th Franco-German Ministerial Council chaired by German Chancellor Friedrich Merz and French President Emmanuel Macron.
- Meeting of Telecoms attachés.

BIRTHDAYS

Former German Chancellor Angela Merkel; European Council President António Costa; MEP Enikő Győri; former MEPs Idoia Villanueva Ruiz, Sofia Ribeiro and Damiano Zoffoli; journalist Carmen Vela; European Parliament’s Natasja Bohez Rubiano; Márton Hajdu, vice president of the Parliamentary Assembly of the Council of Europe; Camilla, duchess of Cornwall; POLITICO’s Samantha Garretto.

Celebrating Saturday: MEP and former Belgian Prime Minister Elio Di Rupo; MEP Matteo Ricci; former MEPs Andrew Lewer and Athanasios Konstantinou; Playbook’s Alex Spence; the FT’s Valentina Pop; European Commission’s Tillmann Heidek; Virgin Group founder Richard Branson; Turkish opposition politician Meral Akşener, a POLITICO 28 alum.

Celebrating Sunday: Former MEP Matt Carthy, now an Irish TD; Roberto Gualtieri, mayor of Rome and a former MEP; former MEP Claudiu Ciprian Tănăsescu; former European Commission Vice President Neelie Kroes; Deputy Ambassador at the U.K. mission to the EU Caroline Read; European Parliament’s Stefano Spinaci and Committee of the Region’s Gianluca Spinaci (who are twins); We. Communications’ James Randerson; Nove’s Tomasz Kaniecki; former Scottish First Minister Nicola Sturgeon.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO’s EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editor James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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